

Executive Function Skills:

~ Activities and Compliments to Support Your Child ~

Executive Function Skills	Target Activities and Strategies	Reflexive Questions to Ask Your Child	Compliments to Give Your Child
Working Memory <i>Holding information in memory while performing complex tasks.</i> 	• When you need to remember something important, write it down in chunks (steps for pet sitting, grocery list, what to bring to school for your presentation/field trip etc.) • Make a memory aid song/acronym to help you remember information (e.g. 50 Nifty United States song or <i>Please Excuse My Dear Aunt Sally</i> for PEDMAS for math) • Repeat instructions out loud • Follow routines (e.g. always put your school bag in the same spot so you can find it) • Visualize • Reduce distractions • Play memory games (e.g. play “Memory” or have a friend put 5 items on a table, then, when you’ve closed your eyes, remove two items)	• How did you remember that so well? Let’s notice it so you can try the same thing next time! • You were so successful using your working memory. How can you use what you just did to help you in the future? • Did you use your acronym? • What strategy could you use to help you remember that? • What strategy did you use to help you remember that? • Did you write down what you have to remember in chunks? • Are you working on things step by step? • Are you finding it difficult to remember what you are studying while you have your music on? • Did you try visualizing what you need to	“I love how you wrote down the important steps Mr. Jones asked you to follow when taking care of Fluffy for him this weekend so you can make sure to do everything you need to do.” “I love that you thought of making an acronym to help you remember the 5 Great Lakes” “Great job turning down the music and repeating the instructions to yourself so you could remember what to pack for soccer.” “Awesome job thinking about what strategy helped you hold information in your mind last time so that you could do it again!” “I could see you completing one task at a time so you wouldn’t overload your working memory capacity! You were able to remember everything you needed while

	and see if you can remember what had been taken) • Complete one task at a time • Play a card game like “Go Fish” and practice remembering what cards the other players have	remember? • Did you repeat the instructions out loud? • Are you trying to do more than one thing at once?	setting up the obstacle course because you did one step at a time.” “I love how when you got stuck at the grocery store, you visualized what we would need to make pancakes so you knew what ingredients to ask Mom to buy.”
Metacognition <i>Noticing how you’re doing. Thinking about how you’re thinking.</i>  METACOGNITION	• Ask yourself if what you are doing is working • Think about yourself as a learner (strengths and weaknesses) • Think about what strategies have helped you in the past • Activate prior knowledge (think about what you already know about a topic) • Think about what type of demands the task entails (e.g. this assignment is going to require a lot of self-monitoring so I should...)	• Does that make sense? • What are you thinking about right now? • What should you be thinking about right now? • What has helped you with this kind of problem before? • What strategies could you try? • Did you look at your chunked instructions? • Did you check off each step? • What would help you figure this out?	“When you kept dropping the stuff you were carrying, I noticed how you thought about it and decided to make two trips because you realized it wasn’t working how you were doing it originally. Great job!” “I loved how you decided to use a strategy from your strategy list when you were writing your essay so that you didn’t stay stuck staring at the page and were able to get started!” “I could tell you were really thinking about your own thinking when you noticed that problem and used your strengths to find a solution!”

Sustained Attention <i>Paying attention, even if you're tired, bored, or not interested.</i> 	• Make sure you are rested and not hungry prior to engaging in a task where you need to stay focused • Take brain breaks where you move your body • Sit in a place with less distractions • Try using a fidget toy • Complete a whole (age-appropriate puzzle) prior to receiving a reward • Break tasks into chunks (e.g. to clean up your room, first put away all the blocks, then put away all the cars etc.) • Exercise regularly • Drink enough water and use restroom prior to an activity requiring sustained focus	• What are you thinking about right now? • What should you be thinking about right now? • Did you notice your attention shift to a different topic? • Did you re-focus your brain when your attention shifted? • Do you need to take a brain break? • When can we take a brain break? (Answer: when the timer goes off) • How did you keep your attention fixed on the topic so well? • Did you prepare yourself to keep your flashlight focused on the topic by filling up your water bottle before we started?	“I noticed you were listening carefully to your gymnastics coach when he was explaining your new move.” “I saw how you finished all the questions on your math page even when you were getting tired!” “Amazing job picking up all your lego. I know it looked like a lot but you stayed focused until the end!” “Thanks for paying attention to where we are going so you can help me not drive past Amanda’s house again.” “I noticed when you were losing focus that you got up and did 5 lunges so you could re-focus yourself.” “Great job taking a bathroom break before the game started to help you stay focused.”
Organization <i>Creating and maintaining a system to keep track of information</i>	• Have a designated spot to store homework materials • Use graphic organizers to plan for assignments • Create lists and have a designated list spot (e.g. on the	• What materials do you need for this activity? • Have you used your graphic organizer? • Did you make an outline?	“I love how you put away your lego before you asked to go to the movies so that you will be able to find it easily next time” “Your backpack looks so much neater now that you have taken out the stuff you don’t need.”

or materials. 	fridge) - Practice organizing toys into separate bins - Deal with clutter (e.g. recycle old papers instead of leaving them in your backpack) - Make outlines	- Did you put your necklace in your jewellery box? - Did you put your soccer shoes in your soccer bag? - Would it help you to make a list? - What would help you stay organized right now?	"I love how you made a list of ingredients so you would know what you needed at the store." "Great work making an outline before you tried to convince dad to get you a cat. Now you can keep track of what you want to say to persuade him."
Response Inhibition <i>Thinking before you act – to resist the urge to say or do things.</i>  RESPONSE INHIBITION	- Take a deep breath or use another calming strategy prior to speaking to someone when you are upset - Check in with yourself and identify strong feelings you are experiencing before taking action - Apologize immediately if you have acted impulsively. - Use a silent fidget toy if you have a tendency to tap pencils/make repetitive sounds - Visualize yourself feeling calm - Before you move on to the next math question, write "DC" next to each question to show that you've double-checked.	- Did you think about what you were going to say before saying it? - How did you wait your turn so well when standing in line for our ice cream? - Did you wait until the timer was done before you moved on? - Did you try a calming strategy? - What calming strategy could help you right now? - How did you stop yourself from shouting when you were upset? - Have you visualized yourself feeling calm? - Did you blow out the candles on all 5 fingers as soon as you felt	"I loved seeing you take a minute to calm down before you started telling us how you feel." "It was awesome to see you stop tapping your pencil like that when your sister told you it was bothering her. You chose to play with your quiet monkey noodle instead so you wouldn't bother others!" "I loved seeing you wait your turn in that game of uno. You were thinking before you acted just like we've been practising!" "Wow, it was wonderful to see you apologize to Sam right away when you realized you had been rude." "I love how you didn't keep rushing ahead to the next thing before you were ready!"

	• Playing an instrument in a group where you have to wait your turn to play your notes • Simon Says • Singing songs in a round • Alternate reading sentences • Use a talking stick in discussion to help you not interrupt others	upset? • Have you tried a yoga break? • What would happen if you didn't help yourself calm down? • Did you check off that step one was complete before moving on to step two? • Did you let Emily finish her turn before you started talking?	You took the time to check that the first step was complete before moving on!" "Great job only doing the action when Simon said to do the action!" "You only talked when you had the talking stick! Amazing job staying quiet while your friend had a turn to talk!"
Flexibility <i>Seeing many sides of an idea or situation. Being able to change and adapt.</i> 	• Truly consider someone else's opinion during a disagreement • Agree to disagree or be open to changing your mind • Try a new way to solve a problem • Be willing to try someone else's idea (e.g. playing a new game/playing a game with different rules than you are used to) • Trying two different approaches to complete the same task • If the materials you normally use for an activity are unavailable, try using something else • Adapt when a favourite	• Did you figure out a way both of you could feel happy? • Can you think of another way we could do this? • What did you tell yourself when you saw Misty sitting in your usual seat? • What else could we use since we don't have your blue pencil? • What else could you do until your bike is fixed? • If you get on the bus this morning and you have a different bus driver, what are three things you could try to help yourself relax? • How did you handle that situation so flexibly? What did you tell	"It was so cool to see you consider your brother's perspective when we had that disagreement about where to go on Saturday." "Great job listening to Daddy when he told you that we can't get ice cream today because the ice cream parlour is closed and being satisfied that maybe we can go next week. You used flexible thinking!" "I know Lilly doesn't do cartwheels the same way you do, but awesome job being flexible and still telling her she looked great even though she does them a different way!" "I love how you convinced yourself you would be ok wearing that green hat when we couldn't find your red one. Awesome

	restaurant is closed by choosing a new place to eat Discuss multiple solutions to handling unexpected situations that could occur in a new environment	yourself as you worked through the challenge?	job staying flexible and finding a solution so you wouldn't stay upset!"
Emotional Control <i>Managing feelings so you can be productive and successful.</i>  EMOTIONAL CONTROL	- Identify your feelings out loud: "I'm feeling very ____" - Affirm yourself. (e.g. "This is hard but I can handle it. I will use my strategies, and I will be ok.") - Ground yourself by noticing five things you can see, four things you can touch, three things you can hear, two things you can smell, one thing you can taste - If a task is overwhelming, focus on calming yourself down prior to starting (e.g. count to ten, deep breaths, sing a song in your head etc) - Recognize if you need to step away for a short break so you don't do something you regret - Focus on something positive (e.g. I will think of a happy memory and then try my task again)	- Did you go to your calming spot when you felt upset? - What things did/could you imagine seeing, touching, hearing, smelling, and tasting to help yourself calm down? - Did you try taking a break? - What happy memory could you think of when you're feeling frustrated? - What can you say to affirm yourself? - What do you like about yourself? - What are you really good at? - Did you visualize yourself feeling in control? - How can you help yourself feel better?	"I love that you kept your voice at a good volume inside Grandma's apartment! Great job with self-control!" "I was so impressed with how you handled your emotions when we found out Jake's birthday party had been cancelled. You controlled your feelings so well." "Amazing job staying calm until I could help you do up your zipper!" "I loved seeing you staying calm when Joe kept whistling the same tune over and over again." "I could see you closing your eyes to visualize yourself feeling in control before you answered me. Amazing job controlling your feelings!" "I felt so proud of you when you told me how you were feeling in a calm voice."

Time Management

Estimating how much time you have and how to use it to stay within time limits and deadlines.



- Set a timer/alarm on your phone
- Establish reminder notifications on your Google calendar
- Wear a watch or sit near a clock when you need to manage time carefully, such as during a test
- Assign a group time manager when working on projects together
- Ask your teacher where the halfway point on your test is and to give you a reminder when half of test-taking time has elapsed to help you stay on track
- Make a schedule of tasks to complete for a big project so most don't get left 'til the last minute
- Make a timeline for getting ready in the morning so you're not so rushed that you miss the bus/don't have time to gather all necessary materials to school

- Did you set a timer?
- Did you put an alarm on your phone?
- Where is your watch?
- How long do you think this will take, and what is half of that?
- When is it reasonable for you to be halfway done?
- Have you been checking off your completed steps/tasks on your timeline?
- Did you ask your teacher or phone to remind you when you are at the halfway point?
- Did you stick to your morning schedule
- How did you stay on task and finish everything on time today? Let's think about it so you know how to do it again next time!

"I love how you put the cookies in to bake before lunch because you know they need time to bake and cool before we can pack them away for our picnic at 3pm. You used your time wisely!"

"I love how you managed your time and got ready quickly so that you would have time to finish shovelling the path before your friend came over to play."

"Awesome job getting dressed so fast. Now we have time to read a book before the school bus comes".

"I was so proud of you when you checked your morning schedule to see what you should do next so that you managed your time well!"

"Fantastic work setting a timer on your phone to alert you that it is 15 minutes before soccer practice so you need to start getting ready. Now we won't be late!"

"You finished half of the questions halfway through the test time. Great job managing your time!"

Planning and Prioritizing

Creating a roadmap to reach a goal or to complete a task. Deciding what is important to focus on and what's not.



PLANNING & PRIORITIZING

- Make an outline prior to completing written assignments
- Make a list of all important tasks to complete your goal (e.g. what do I need to do before we leave for our trip)
- Refer back to this list regularly
- Identify the three most important items on your list and start with them
- Refer to teacher checklists and rubrics
- Have regular check-ins with a parent/teacher/buddy to help you stay on task
- When reading, highlight words you do not understand and prioritize learning their meaning
- Rate the importance of tasks (e.g. for the science fair project, is it more important to draw an incredible border on the bristol board, or more important to write out the science information?)

- Did you make an outline?
- What should we do first?
- What would happen if we didn't do x first?
- Is that a major or a minor issue/point/decision?
- Did you do a teacher check-in?
- Check your rubric. Is that what the teacher wants?
- What is the most important job to finish first?
- How did you make that awesome plan? Let's make sure we review what you did so you can do it again next time!
- How did you prioritize those tasks so well?
- What is the most important part of this assignment?
- What is something that you could leave to the end and only do if you have time left over?

"I love how you made sure you had everything you would need at swimming lessons by packing your swim bag the night before! Great planning!"

"I love how you raked the leaves first since Dad said it was going to snow tomorrow and you left the window washing inside for after, even though you find window washing more enjoyable. It isn't affected by the weather, so it was smart to do the leaves before they got covered in snow! Great prioritizing!"

"It was awesome to see you starting on your Science project today. You should have lots of time to finish it well since it isn't due for a week. Great planning!"

"I love how you finished the purpose, hypothesis, method, results, and conclusion sections before decorating your project!"

"Awesome job ranking the things you have to do in order of importance! Now you know what to do first!"

Amazing job making such a clear plan with all the steps written out. It is so clear what you need to do when.

Task Initiation

The ability to begin projects in a timely fashion.



**TASK
INITIATION**

- Ask yourself what you need to do first to get started
- Think of strategies that have helped you get started in the past
- Begin with an outline
- Ask your teacher for a sentence starter prompt
- Tell yourself that you will jot basic points down first and fix them up later so it feels more manageable
- Remind yourself that you don't have to get things all right at the beginning

- What do you need to do to get started?
- Where is your outline?
- Do you have a graphic organizer?
- What is the first step?
- Did you remind yourself we can fix up the details later?
- What has helped you get started in the past?
- How did you get yourself started so quickly this time? Let's notice it so you can try the same things next time!

"I love how you started on the dishes right after dinner without being asked! Now you have an hour of free time - want to play a game together?"

"I know you're excited to enter your art in that contest and I think it's so awesome that you're starting on your portfolio with plenty of time to spare."

"I like how you set a reward and got to eat a popsicle after you made your outline"

"I love how you used a strategy independently to get yourself started! Great job improving your task initiation skills!"

Goal-Directed Persistence

Following through to the completion of your goal without being distracted by competing interests.



- Start big tasks/assignments by breaking them into manageable chunks
- Make a goal for the day/class period and try to achieve it
- Check tasks off your list as you complete them rather than starting something else
- Affirm yourself as you complete steps
- Check in with yourself if you start to zone out and take a short brain break as needed
- Refer back to rubrics/teacher instructions regularly
- If your activity fails, consider new approaches and try again until you achieve success

- What is your goal for today?
- What is your goal for the next 5 minutes?
- How will you know when you're done?
- Did you check off your completed tasks?
- Did you refer back to the rubric?
- Did you think of a new approach when the first one didn't work?
- Before you handed that in, did you check it matches with the expectations?
- How did you keep yourself on track to achieve your goals without getting discouraged and giving up? Let's notice what you did so you can be sure to do it again next time!

"I love how you were so patient when writing that essay. You made your outline, then your sloppy copy, then you revised, then you completed your final draft so that you can focus on key areas one at a time!"

"I love how you checked over your suitcase to make sure you packed everything you needed instead of just throwing it all in and leaving without double-checking."

"When your cake didn't turn out, I loved how you watched youtube videos and tried again and again until it came out how you wanted it to be! Great job being persistent!"

"I know it can be hard to train Butch to fetch the stick. I love that you didn't give up and kept on trying to teach him until it finally clicked for him! Amazing job persevering and not giving up on your goals!"

Reference:

Activated Learning Teaching Approach ©Laurie Faith, 2017, @LCFaith, [ActivatedLearning.org](http://activatedlearning.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/01/EF-BASICS-LESSON-SERIES-PDF.p)
<http://activatedlearning.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/01/EF-BASICS-LESSON-SERIES-PDF.p>